HEALING AND FORGIVENESS: SICKNESS AND SIN

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Four religious attitudes have been taken toward sickness. Most extreme, (1) sickness is an illusion, an idea associated with quasi-Christian groups and some Eastern thought. (2) Sickness indicates sinfulness. Passages like the following help avoid this mistake: the whole Book of Job; John **9**:1-3ff.; Acts **28**:1-6. There is not a correlation between a sin and a suffering (the "moralizing view of history"), nor is there a correlation between the degree of sinfulness and the degree of suffering (Psalm **73**; Jeremiah **12**:1-2; Malachi **3**:15; Luke **13**:1-5; 2 Corinthians **12**:7-9). (3) Sickness is a feature of Satan's rule that is overcome in Christ; consequently, Christians are freed from what characterizes the devil's dominion. (4) Sickness is a continuing part of human life, potentially rather always overcome by prayer or miracle; its complete removal comes at the eschaton.

Despite passages like those noted, some Christians continue to correlate sin and suffering and therefore forgiveness and healing. Usually, the idea is not that a one-for-one correlation exists between a sin and a suffering in a causal sense (option #2 above). It is the somewhat freer belief that Christians should expect a high proportion of deliverance from sickness (options #3). Disease, deformity, and death are manifestations of the kingdom of darkness that Christ has conquered. Only in exceptional cases would there be any rationale for Christian suffering.

1. The first source of confusion is that scripture uses *sickness* to picture sin. Sin is to a society what disease is to the body; healing, then, is to disease what forgiveness is to sin. In the Old Testament, sickness as a figure for sinfulness is additionally integrated into Israel's national calamities because God did not protect the nation when its people sinned. As the data below show, recovering from the ravages of war (national) correlates with recovering from wounds (physical), which correlates with forgiven sin (spiritual) pictured as healing.

2. A related source of confusion is that sin and sickness are combined in several texts; so a reader can misconstrue their connection. In a context about the atonement, **(a)** Isaiah **53** speaks of being healed by the stripes of one who took on himself our infirmities and bore our diseases. Matthew, in fact, cites Isaiah **53**:4 in commenting on Jesus' healings (**8**:17). Isaiah's prediction must have some connection with Christ's healing ministry, not just in the sense that sickness can figuratively represent sin, but in the sense that sickness is or can be overcome in him. An atonement-healing connection may be made, however, without having characteristic deliverance before the final resurrection. If suffering, sickness, and death came originally because of sin, then Christ's solving the sin problem implies his solving the sickness and death problems as well. But even as death and calamity are not uniformly overcome this side of the consummation, so also disease and sickness are not uniformly overcome till then. Besides being indicative of divine sanction, first-century resurrections and healings were omens of that later uniformity; they were not the beginning of a present one. In the "now," God has *"appointed people . . . to die"* (Hebrews **9**:27). Whether by miracle or answered prayer, not everyone received healing for every malady even while Christ was here (2 Corinthians **12**:7-10; 1 Timothy **5**:23; 2 Timothy **4**:20).

Mixing sin and sickness occurs also in **(b)** Mark **2**:1-12, where four men lowered a paralytic through the roof to get Jesus to heal him, and Jesus forgave his sin (Mark **2**:1-12). The link between healing and forgiveness here is not that the two coincide, but that in this instance Jesus used the former to prove he had the right to do the latter. (c) In Luke **13**:1-5 Jesus disavows any correlation between the degree of sinfulness and the degree of suffering, but does tell his audience to repent or they will perish like those whose blood Pilate had mingled with their sacrifices and like the ones the tower of Siloam fell on.

(d) After healing a crippled man at the Pool of Bethesda (John **5**:2-9), Jesus tells him sometime later to "sin no more lest a worse thing befall" him (**5**:14). Jesus may have said that lest the man succumb to pressure from the Pharisees to point out who had told him to carry his bedroll on the Sabbath (**5**:9b-13, 15-18). More likely he means that falling into sin is a worse fate than being crippled. At any rate, in both Luke **13** and John **5**, Jesus uses suffering as a frame of reference for appreciating the destructive power of sin. Sin is worse than being crippled and more devastating than death by the sword or a collapsing tower. Most healings do not mention forgiveness, and Jesus pronounces forgiveness aside from healings—as in the case of the sinful woman who anointed his feet and wiped them with her hair (Luke **7**:36-50). So, we need not correlate the frequency of the two.

When he tells the sick to call the elders, **(e)** James includes a comment about forgiveness (**5**:13-18). That forgiveness characteristically accompanies healing, nevertheless, is not said. The point may be that whenever people seek God in one way, they receive other benefits. Singing praise and sincerely praying for healing reveal the same attitude God requires for overlooking sin. Furthermore, inferring the uniformity of healing and forgiveness and a correlation between the two is not necessary because James' promise is no more absolute than promises elsewhere about answered prayer generally (Matthew **21**:21-22; cp. **17**:19-20; Mark **10**:23-24; John **15**:16b; **16**:23-24). James **5** is not talking, then, about <u>miracle</u>—with uniformity between attempt and success, nor is he saying that healing from prayer always occurs. Much less does he connect healing and forgiveness as if sin had caused that sickness or as if healing was as uniform as forgiveness. He only states a principle.

(f) Asa, king of Judah, is criticized in 2 Chronicles **16**:11-14 for going to the doctors instead of the Lord. But the reason may be that he went <u>only</u> to them even though the kind of problem he had was nothing doctors of his day could handle. His failure to do so parallels his lack of resistance to idolatry in his realm. (See also Psalm **107**:17-20 for a connection between sin, forgiveness, and healing.)

3. A third source of confusion is that we know <u>sin does bring negative consequences</u>. That is one reason it is sin: it is contrary to human nature and relationships. Sin associates with suffering in three ways. **(a)** Negative experiences come into human life indiscriminately because of <u>the original sin</u>. Death comes ultimately from sin; death and the experiences that tend toward it God put in the human condition as an act of grace—to force people to recognize their limitedness and their dependent position under him (Genesis **3**:22-24; Romans **5**:12-14). Death also brings evil people to an end. **(b)** Negative experiences come on some people because of <u>the sins of other people</u>. In the social situation, what one person does affects other persons. Finally, **(c)** negative experiences do come into a people's life because of <u>their own sin</u>; sometimes they come by natural consequence and occasionally by divine punishment (Genesis **3**; **6**:5ff.; **18**:16-21; **38**:7, 8-11; Exodus **32**:21-35; Leviticus **10**:1-7; Numbers **14**; **16**; **21**; Acts **5**:1-11; **12**:20-23; **13**:4-12; and the Book of Jonah). The point is that not <u>all</u> negative consequences come from <u>personal</u> sin.

4. A fourth source of confusion is that from the standpoint of modern English, scripture mixes salvation and healing terminology. English uses *healing* for physical sores and wounds, but scripture uses *healing* for spiritual "salvation" as well—along with several other matters that need correcting. Christians use *saving* primarily for spiritual matters or from external dangers, but scripture uses *saving* to indicate physical healing as well. When English Christians read *heal*, they think of physical healing; and when they see *save*, they think of spiritual salvation. The cross-over in biblical terminology can cause them to associate being "saved" with being "healed." That impulse reinforces the belief that sickness correlates with sin, that salvation includes delivery from both, and offers it now.

The following data show the range of New and Old Testament words for healing physical maladies, deformities, wounds, sickness, and disease, as well as the inability to conceive children. It applies to emotional conditions, spiritual lostness, political upheaval, chemical contamination, ceremonial uncleanness, and demonic possession. The New Testament terms are ἰάομαι/ἴασις/ἴαμα, and θεραπεύω; the Old Testament root is רפה.

I. Physical

A. Specific physical maladies

athlete's foot/gangrene?: 2 Chronicles **16**:12
boils: Leviticus **13**:18; Deuteronomy **28**:27; 2 Kings **20**:5, 8 (+ **20**:7)
dropsy: Luke **14**:3[a], 4
dysentery: Acts **28**:8
epilepsy: Matthew **4**:24[a]
itch: Leviticus **13**:27; Deuteronomy **28**:27
leprosy: Leviticus **14**:3; Numbers **12**:13; Luke **17**:15
menstrual bleeding: Mark **5**:28 (= Luke **8**:47)
palsy: Matthew **8**:7[a]; **8**:8 (= Lk. **7**:7); Luke **5**:17; Acts **9**:34
scurvy: Deuteronomy **28**:27
severe weight loss ("withering away"): Psalm **6**:2 (3)

B. Specific physical handicaps

blindness: Matthew **12**:22[a]; **15**:30[a]; **21**:14[a]
lameness/crippledness (χωλός, παραλυτικός, κυλλός): Matthew **4**:24[a]; **15**:30[2a]; **21**:14[a]; John **5**:13; Acts **3**:11; **4**:22; Hebrews **12**:13;
muteness/deafness: Matthew **12**:22[a]; **15**:30
withered hand: Matthew **12**:10[a] [= Mark **3**:2[a]]

C. Wounds

from a whip: Isaiah **53**:5
injury: Exodus **21**:19, 21
"wounds": Deuteronomy **32**:39; 2 Kings **8**:29; **9**:15; 2 Chronicles **22**:6; Job **5**:18; Isaiah **30**:26 (as a figure for general prosperity in the land); Jeremiah **15**:18 (fig.); **30**:17 (fig.); **51**:8; Hosea **5**:13 (fig.); **6**:1

healing *vs*. smiting: Isaiah **19**:22
pains/torments: Matthew **4**:24[a]
Malchus' severed ear: Luke **22**:51
crucifixion: Luke **4**:23 (= **23**:35?)

D. Restoring the ability to produce children: Genesis **20**:17

E. "Sickness(es)": Psalm **107**:20 + 17-19; Ezekiel **34**:4; Hosea **5**:13; Matthew **4**:23[a] (μαλακία); **8**:16[a] [= Mark **1**:34] (κακῶς ἔχοντες); Matthew **9**:35[a] (μαλακία); **10**:1[a] (μαλακία), 8[a]; **14**:14[a] (ἄρρωστοι); Mark **6**:5[a] (ἄρρωστοι); Luke **9**:2 (ἀσθενής); John **4**:47 (ἀσθενέω); **5**:5 (ἀσθένειαι) "diseases": Exodus **15**:26; Psalm **103**:3; Matthew **4**:23[a], 24[a]; **9**:35[a]; **10**:1[a]; Mark **1**:34[a]; **3**:10[a] (μάστιξ); Luke **8**:16 (νόσοι)

F. What prevents dying: Psalm **30**:2 (3); Ecclesiastes **3**:3 (healing *vs*. butchering?)

G. "Physicians": Genesis **50**:2[2] (embalmers); Job **13**:4 (fig.); Jeremiah **8**:22 (fig.)

H. General reference: Matthew **12**:15; **19**:2; Luke **9**:11; Acts **4**:30; James **5**:16

II. Emotional

brokenheartedness: Psalm **147**:3; Luke **4:**18 < Isaiah **61**:1 (Septuagint—LXX)

III. Spiritual

backsliding: Jeremiah **3**:22; Hosea **14**:4 (5)
sin: Isaiah **6**:10 (fig.); **57**:18-19; Jeremiah **17**:14?; Matthew **13**:15 [= Jn. **12**:40 = Acts **28**:27] < Isaiah **6**:10
"heal the soul": Psalm **41**:4 (5)

IV. Ceremonial

2 Chronicles **30**:20: because of special circumstances on one occasion during Hezekiah's reign, God granted ceremonial cleanness to some people who had not purified themselves according to the Law for observing the Passover. The text calls granting that ceremonial cleanness, "healing."

V. Political

"heal Babylon": Jeremiah **51**:8, 9
"heal the city": Jeremiah **33**:6 (independence?)
"heal Israel/Ephraim": Hosea **7**:1; **11**:3
"heal the land": 2 Chronicles **7**:14
"heal nations": Revelation **22**:2[a]
political unrest: Jeremiah **6**:14 = **8**:11
heal from the ravages of warfare: Jeremiah **8**:22 (Is "heal the daughter of Zion" figurative for recovering from the ravages of war?)

VI. Demonic

possession: Matthew **4**:24[a]; **12**:22[a]; **15**:21-28 (cp. Mark **7**:24-30); **17**:16[a], 18[a]; Luke **6**:18[a]; **9**:42
oppression: Acts **10**:38

VII. Miscellaneous

Repairing inanimate objects
broken vessels: Jeremiah **19**:11
an altar: 1 Kings **18**:20
breaches in a wall: Psalm **60**:2 (4); Lamentations **2**:13
broken things: Zechariah **11**:16
Getting rid of a fungus (?) in the walls of a house: Leviticus **14**:48
Making water drinkable: 2 Kings **2**:21, 22 (poisoned?); Ezekiel **47**:8, 9, 11 (brackish?)

The New Testament data for *saving* (σώζω, *sōizō*) is less complex. In the gospels it usually indicates saving from something besides sin. In the epistles, however, saving almost always refers to saving from sin. The data can be arranged as follows:

I. Spiritual: salvation from sin

Matthew **1**:21; **10**:22; **18**:11; **19**:25; **24**:13 (= Mark **13**:13); Mark **8**:35b (= Luke **9**:24b); **10**:26; **13**:13; **16**:16; Luke **8**:12; **13**:23; **18**:26; **19**:10; John **3**:17; **5**:34; **10**:9; **12**:47; Acts **2**:21, 40, 47; **4**:12; **11**:14; **15**:1, 11; **16**:30, 31; Romans **5**:9, 10; **8**:24; **9**:27; **10**:9, 13; **11**:14, 26; 1 Corinthians **1**:18, 21; **3**:15; **5**:5; **7**:16[2]; **9**:22; **10**:33; **15**:2; 2 Corinthians **2**:15; Ephesians **2**:5, 8; 1 Thessalonians **2**:16; 2 Thessalonians **2**:10; 1 Timothy **1**:15; **2:**4, 15; **4**:16; 2 Timothy **1**:9; **4**:18; Titus **3**:5; Hebrews **7**:25; James **2**:21; **2**:14; **4**:12; **5**:20; 1 Peter **3**:21; **4**:18; Jude 23

II. Physical: salvation from things other than sin

from death: in the sea (Matthew **8**:25; **14**:30; Acts **27**:20, 31), in warfare (Matthew **24**:22 = Mk. **13**:20), by crucifixion (Matthew **27**:40/42/49 = Mark **15**:30/31 = Luke **23**:35/37/39; John **12**:27; Hebrews **5**:7), from sickness (Mark **5**:23; John **11**:12);
from menstrual bleeding: Matthew **9**:21, 22[2] (= Mark **5**:28, 34; Luke **8**:48, 50)
life: Matthew **16**:25 (= Mark **8**:35a = Luke **9**:24a); Mark **3**:4 (= Luke **6**:9)
general: Mark **6**:56
blindness: Mark **10**:52 (= Luke **18**:42)
lameness: Acts **4**:9 (+ **3**:2); **14**:9
sickness: James **5**:15